

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

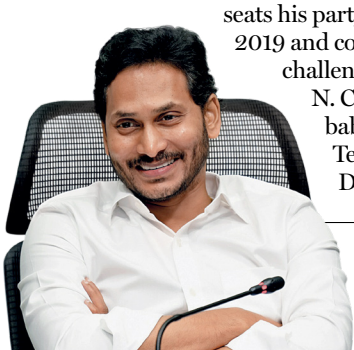
GLASSHOUSE

CHOWKIDAR OF THE EAST

No one has imbibed the lessons of the BJP's 2019 'Main Bhi Chowkidar' (I'm also a watchman) campaign better than Assam cabinet minister **Pijush Hazarika**. The most trusted lieutenant of Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Hazarika has emerged as the watchman of backdoor operations of the BJP in Assam in the past five years. When rebel Shiv Sena MLAs landed at Guwahati's Radisson Blu hotel on June 22, Hazarika and his team kept a hawk eye on the people in and around the hotel, thwarting every infiltration attempt by Sena emissaries. Hazarika is a past master at the task—he had kept watch over potentially poachable MLAs during government formation in Manipur in 2017 and again in Meghalaya in 2018, when the BJP and allies did not have the required numbers. Now, the role comes naturally to him.

Polls Apart

Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, the chief minister of Andhra Pradesh and founder of YSRC party, has long wanted to delink the state assembly election from the Lok Sabha polls, unlike in 2014 and 2019. Now, he is set to hold the party plenary in Guntur on July 8-9, after a break of five years. He aims to organise the party around state-level polling booths. He has set a goal of winning more seats than the 151 of the 175 seats his party won in 2019 and counter the challenge from N. Chandrababu Naidu's Telugu Desam Party.



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ENLARGED ESTATE



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Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao**'s decision to allot prime government land cheaply to set up TRS district party offices is being challenged in the High Court. As per an August 17, 2018 order, the government can allot land up to an acre (4,840 sq. yards) each to recognised political parties to build offices. On May 11 this year, the ruling TRS got 4,935 sq. yards at the same price in Hyderabad's upscale Banjara Hills area where it had built the state party office on government-allotted land in 2006.



NO ONE'S HANUMAN

I am not Hanuman. I am no one's Hanuman. My name is Ramchandra. Make no mistake." So shot back Union minister **R.C.P. Singh** on June 26, when journalists in the Jamui district of Bihar described him as Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's Hanuman. It is now clear that the IAS officer-turned-politician, who was denied a Rajya Sabha nomination, no longer wants to be seen as a Nitish follower. He may well have been reminded of LJP leader Chirag Paswan's reference to being PM Narendra Modi's Hanuman.



Grouse Over Gaushala

Pinarayi Vijayan may be no *gaubhakt*, but Kerala under his rule is seeing a white revolution: annual milk production in 2021-22 hit 25.49 metric tonnes. Pinarayi has been rearing cows at Cliff House, his official residence, since he became chief minister in 2016. However, his intention to build a cattle shed triggered a controversy in Kerala after the PWD ministry in the state, headed by his son-in-law Mohammed Riyas, sanctioned Rs 42.9 lakh for the project on June 22. That's a high price for *gaubhakti* in the south, it would seem.

–Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Amarnath K. Menon and Jeemon Jacob